

Online Graph Embedding in Star Graphs

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TU Berlin

ICDCS 2026

Outline

Online Graph Embedding

Related Work & Contributions

The Deterministic Case

The Randomized Case

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Introducing Online Graph Embedding

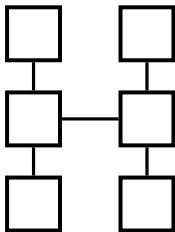
Graph embedding involves two graphs:

- the **guest graph**: the graph to be embedded, and
- the **host graph**: the graph into which the guest is embedded.

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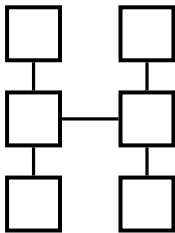


Host graph H

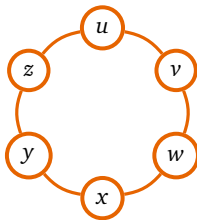
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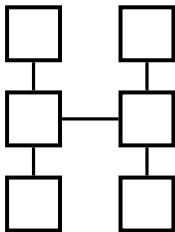


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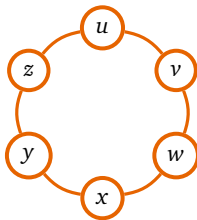
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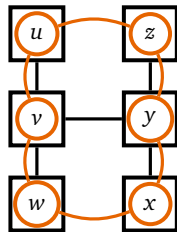
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Host graph H



Guest graph G



An embedding of G in H

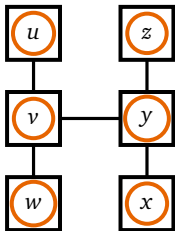
This embedding has a total cost of 12.

Graph Embedding: the Online Variant

In the online variant, the guest graph is **revealed edge by edge** and not all at once.

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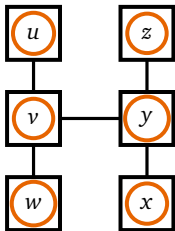
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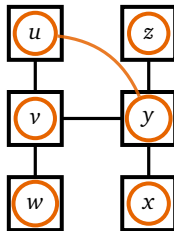
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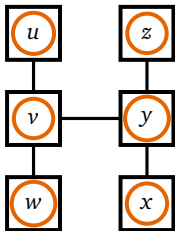
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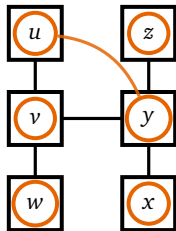
Edge $\{u, y\}$ revealed (cost 2)

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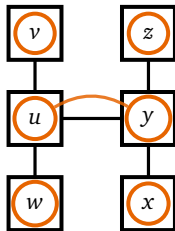
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Initial embedding



Edge $\{u, y\}$ revealed (cost 2)



Swap $u \leftrightarrow v$ (cost 1). Now serving $\{u, y\}$ would cost 1

Online Graph Embedding: Problem Statement

Input.

- A **host graph** $H = (V_H, E_H)$ with distance d_H
- A **guest graph** $G = (V_G, E_G)$ such that $|V_G| = |V_H|$
- An initial bijection $\phi_0 : V_G \rightarrow V_H$
- A sequence of edge requests $\sigma = e_1, e_2, \dots$, $e_i \in E_G$, revealed **one by one**

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Per request $e_i = \{u, v\}$. The algorithm may first **reconfigure** ϕ (swap two guest nodes), then must **serve** e_i :

$$\text{cost}(e_i) = \underbrace{d_\tau(\phi_{i-1}, \phi_i)}_{\text{reconfig.}} + \underbrace{d_H(\phi_i(u), \phi_i(v))}_{\text{serving}}$$

where d_τ counts the number of swaps.

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Competitive analysis

Algorithm Alg is **c -competitive** if for every request sequence σ :

$$\text{Alg}(\sigma) \leq c \cdot \text{Opt}(\sigma)$$

where Opt is the best *offline* algorithm.

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Related Work

Single-node requests

Classical online data-structure problems where each request touches *one* node:

- **List access problem** [Sleator and Tarjan 1985]: minimise access + transposition cost on a linked list.
- **Self-adjusting BSTs** (splay trees) [Sleator and Tarjan 1985]: restructure a search tree after each query.
- **VM migration** [Kamali and López-Ortiz 2013]: move a single virtual machine to reduce access cost.

⇒ *Requests involve a single node; interaction between pairs is not considered.*

Pairwise requests (our setting)

Problems where each request involves a *pair* of nodes:

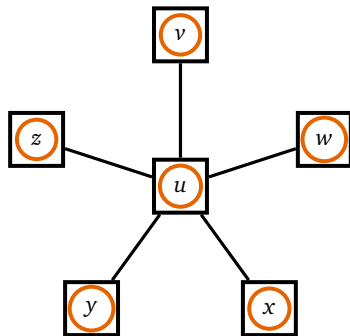
- **Dynamic graph partitioning** [Avin + 2020; Henzinger + 2019; Henzinger + 2021]: intra-cluster cost 0, inter-cluster cost 1.
- **Dynamic min. linear arrangement** [Olver + 2018; Bienkowski and Even 2024]: nodes on a line; cost = distance between requested pair.
- **Online graph embedding** (this work): general host graph; reconfiguration by node swaps.

⇒ *Pairwise interactions require tracking pairs of nodes simultaneously. Strictly harder.*

Contributions

For the online embedding problem in star graphs, we derive **optimal online algorithms** for both the deterministic and randomized setting.

	Lower bound	Algorithm
Deterministic	$3/2$	$3/2$
Randomized	$11/9$	$11/9$



⇒ We present the first optimal algorithm for the fundamental case of a node and its neighborhood.

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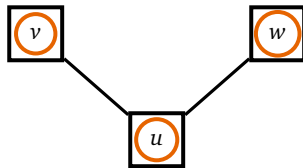
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Deterministic Lower Bound: 1.5

Setup. Fix any deterministic algorithm Alg and three guest nodes u, v, w on a 3-node star host.

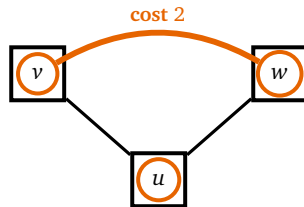


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Setup. Fix any deterministic algorithm Alg and three guest nodes u, v, w on a 3-node star host.

Adversarial Request Sequence σ . Always request the *two nodes not at Alg's center*.

$\Rightarrow$ Alg pays **2** per request, every time.



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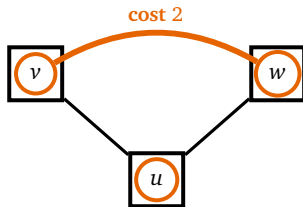
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Offline optimum. One node appears in $\geq \frac{2}{3}|\sigma|$ requests, say it is u . Define Opt that places u at the center and do not move. Then:

$$\text{Opt}(\sigma) \leq \underbrace{1 \cdot \frac{2}{3}|\sigma|}_{\text{involving center}} + \underbrace{2 \cdot \frac{1}{3}|\sigma|}_{\text{others}} = \frac{4}{3}|\sigma|$$



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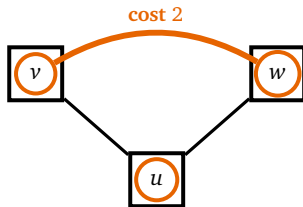
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Ratio. $\frac{\text{Alg}(\sigma)}{\text{Opt}(\sigma)} \geq \frac{2|\sigma|}{\frac{4}{3}|\sigma|} = \frac{3}{2}$



PivotTracking: Our Deterministic Algorithm

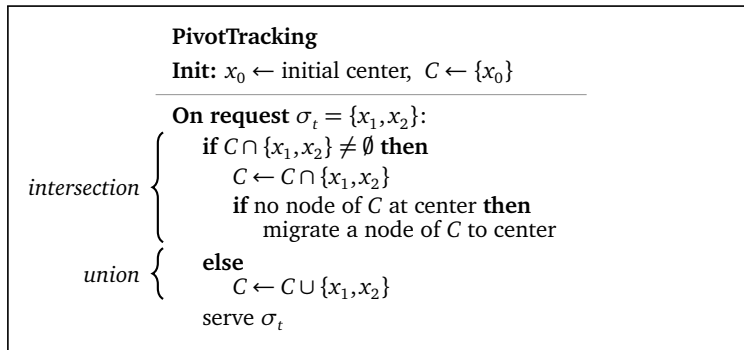
Main Idea. Maintain a **candidate set** C of guest nodes that Opt might be keeping at the center.

- If the requested edge intersects C , migrate a requested node to the center (**intersection behavior**).
- Else, grow the candidate set (**union behavior**).

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A Few Helpful Definitions

Phase and pivot

A **phase** of an algorithm is a maximal run of requests during which its central node does not change. The central node during a phase is called the **pivot**.

Opt^*

The optimal offline algorithm that minimizes the *reversed lexicographic order* on phase lengths, i.e. it delays phase changes as long as possible.

Cheap and expensive requests

A request σ_i is **cheap** if Opt^* pays 1 for it, and **expensive** if Opt^* pays 2.

The Tracking Lemma

Tracking Lemma

Let σ_i be any request and C the candidate set. Then:

Alg uses **intersection** $\iff \sigma_i$ is cheap Alg uses **union** $\iff \sigma_i$ is expansive

Intersection behavior

$$C \leftarrow C \cap \sigma_i$$

Migrate a node from C to center if needed.

Union behavior

$$C \leftarrow C \cup \sigma_i$$

No migration.

Proof of the Tracking Lemma (1/2): Cheap $\Rightarrow$ Intersection

We prove the claim by induction on the successive requests.

Claim. If σ_i is cheap, then Alg uses **intersection**.

Recall. σ_i is cheap means Opt^* pays 1, so the pivot x of the current phase is in σ_i .

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Step 1. x is in C at the start of the phase.

- *Base case (first phase):* x was inserted in C at initialization.
- *Later phase:* by induction: a phase starts with an expensive request containing x so Alg applied **union** $\Rightarrow x$ entered C .

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Step 2. x stays in C from the phase start up to σ_i .

- **Expensive** requests only *add* nodes to C : x not removed.
- **Cheap** requests intersect C with σ_j , which always contains x (since x is the pivot and Opt^* pays 1): x stays.

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Conclusion.

$$x \in C \quad \text{and} \quad x \in \sigma_i \quad \Rightarrow \quad C \cap \sigma_i \neq \emptyset \quad \Rightarrow \quad \text{Alg uses } \mathbf{intersection}. \quad \square$$

Proof of the Tracking Lemma (2/2): Expensive $\Rightarrow$ Union

Claim. If σ_i is expensive, Alg uses **union**. Proof by **contradiction**: assume Alg uses intersection.

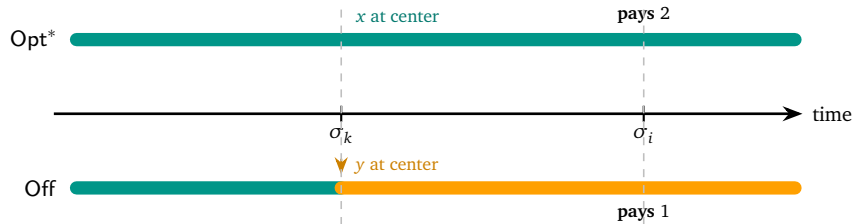
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Construct Off: act like Opt^* , but *migrate y to center just before σ_k* and keep it there through σ_i .



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Off **saves 1 on σ_i** .

- $y \in \sigma_i$ but $x \notin \sigma_i$ (since σ_i is expensive, the pivot x is *not* in σ_i).
- Off has y at center $\Rightarrow$ pays 1. Opt^* has x at center $\Rightarrow$ pays 2.

The migration cost of y is *already covered*: by induction, σ_k was expensive, so Opt^* also paid a migration cost there.

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After σ_i : two cases, both give a contradiction:

- **x never appears again in the phase:** Off pays $\leq \text{Opt}^*$ on all remaining requests, but already saved 1 on $\sigma_i \Rightarrow$ Off strictly better than Opt^* . **Contradiction.**
- **x appears later at $\sigma_{k'}$:** Let Off migrate x at $\sigma_{k'}$ (cost +1), losing the saving. Total cost = Opt^* , but the phase of x at center is *shorter* $\Rightarrow$ Off has smaller reversed lexicographic order than Opt^* . **Contradiction.**

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Conclusion. Both cases contradict the definition of Opt^* .

Intersection on expensive request is impossible $\Rightarrow$ Alg uses **union**. $\square$

Proving 1.5-Competitiveness: Block Decomposition

Main idea. Partition σ into *blocks*, analyse each block separately, and show the ratio is ≤ 1.5 on every block.

Using the tracking lemma, label each request:

$\mathcal{E}$ = expensive request, Γ = cheap request.

Block decomposition of σ :

$$\sigma = \underbrace{\Gamma^*}_{\text{prefix}} \underbrace{\left(\mathcal{E}^+ \Gamma^+\right)^*}_{\text{block}} \underbrace{\mathcal{E}^*}_{\text{suffix}}$$

A **block** $B = \mathcal{E}^+ \Gamma^+$: one or more expensive requests followed by one or more cheap requests.

Proving 1.5-Competitiveness: Block Decomposition

$$\sigma = \Gamma^* \left(\mathcal{E}^+ \Gamma^+ \right)^* \mathcal{E}^*$$

Prefix and suffix are easy.

- **Prefix** Γ^* : all requests are cheap. By tracking lemma, Alg uses intersection: it never pays more than Opt^* . Ratio ≤ 1 .
- **Suffix** $\mathcal{E}^*$: all requests are expensive. Alg uses union: no migration, pays 2 per request. Opt^* also pays ≥ 2 (migration + serve or just 2). Ratio ≤ 1 .

It remains to analyse each **block** $B = \mathcal{E}^+ \Gamma^+$.

Proving 1.5-Competitiveness: Block Decomposition

Analysis of a block B with ε expensive and γ cheap requests.

Opt^* pays exactly:

$$\text{Opt}^*(B) = 2\varepsilon + \gamma$$

Alg on the γ cheap requests (intersection behavior): C shrinks at most **twice** during a block, each shrink costs at most 1 extra.

$$\text{Alg}(B) \leq 2\varepsilon + \gamma + \min(2, \gamma)$$

Competitive ratio on B :

$$\frac{\text{Alg}(B)}{\text{Opt}^*(B)} \leq \frac{2\varepsilon + \gamma + \min(2, \gamma)}{2\varepsilon + \gamma} \leq 1 + \frac{2}{2 \cdot 1 + 2} = \frac{3}{2} \quad \square$$

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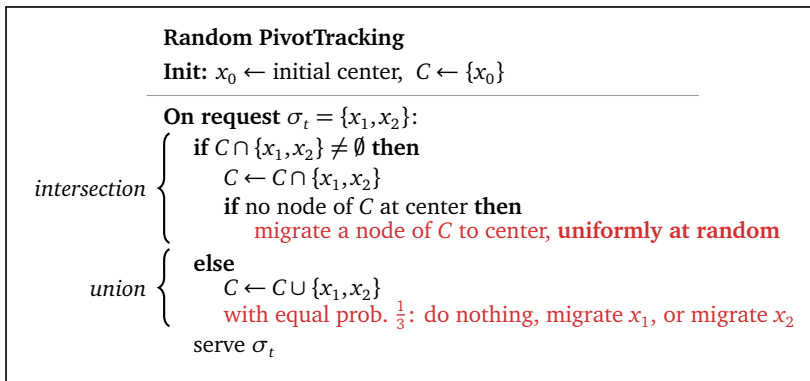
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Random PivotTracking

Same structure as PivotTracking, with **two randomized tweaks**:



We prove that Random PivotTracking has a competitive ratio of $11/9 \approx 1.22$.
The proof uses a slightly more complicated block partition of the input sequence.

Randomized Lower Bound: 11/9

The adversary constructs the sequence as **pairs** of requests. Each pair has a **pivot** : the node the offline algorithm Off keeps at the center.

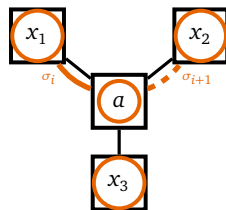
Pattern 1 (prob. p): pivot a appears in *both* requests.

$$(\{a, x_1\}, \{a, x_2\})$$

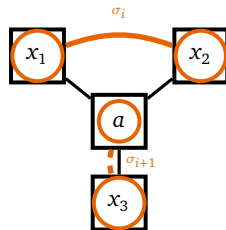
Pattern 2 (prob. $1-p$): pivot a (from prev. pair) appears only in the *second* request.

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Pattern 1 (pivot a in both)



Pattern 2 (pivot a in 2nd only)



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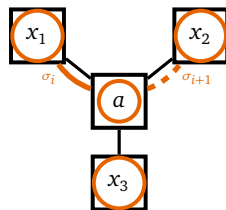
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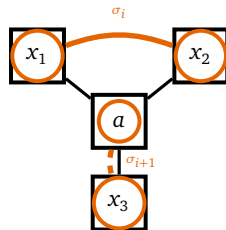
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Off migrates a to center before each pair $\Rightarrow$ pays exactly **3** per pair.

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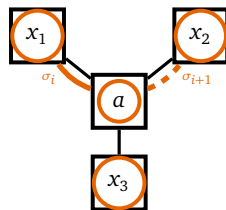
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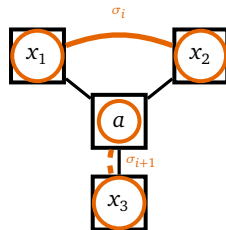
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Main Idea. Set $p = \frac{2}{3}$: any deterministic Alg pays $\geq \frac{11}{3}$ per pair in expectation.

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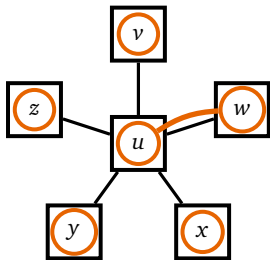


Conclusion

- We introduced **online graph embedding** in star graphs: guest edges revealed one by one, algorithm serves and reconfigures.
- Proved **tight** competitive ratios:
 - $3/2$ for deterministic algorithms
 - $11/9$ for randomized algorithms

Open questions

- Extend to **more complex host graphs** (paths, trees, general topologies).
- Online embedding with **weighted** edges or **capacitated** hosts.



Thank you for your attention!

J. Dallot D. Melnyk M. Pacut S. Schmid

TU Berlin — ICDCS 2026

	Lower bound	Algorithm
Deterministic	$3/2$	$3/2$
Randomized	$11/9$	$11/9$

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